

back pocket—and without shaming you for not knowing everything about something most of us were never taught to begin with. What I am offering is imperfect, and it will not solve everything, but you will learn some things that might really help you. I promise not to be boring or patronizing or offensive or manipulative along the way. I can't promise I won't put on big sunglasses at some point, but this is a book so you *probably* won't see them.

Welcome to the first honest conversation about money you've ever had.

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As I've learned through my *Bad with Money* podcast and the reactions to articles I've written on my own money foibles, my willingness to admit what I don't know is apparently rare—rarer than I thought when I started my imperfect journey of openly sharing my problems with money. It turns out that *no one* wants to talk about money. Not the rich. Not the poor. Not anyone in between. (Which, by the way, makes you a hero for picking up this book. Quick! Buy it and run somewhere private to read it!)

In the first episode of *Bad with Money*, I asked random patrons at a coffee shop two questions. First was, “What's your favorite sex position?” Everyone was game to answer that one: reverse cowgirl, missionary, 69. (I'm kidding. No one's favorite is 69.) Even the barista jumped in with an enthusiastic “doggy style!” I heard it all. Then I asked people how much money was in their bank accounts. Everyone was horrified. “That's a very personal question!” I heard amid gasps. People probably would have rather showed me their browser histories. (And to be honest, I would have liked to see them! I'm a perv!)

Clearly, money is a subject no one wants to dissect. So let's start this book by addressing the first big obstacle I faced when confronting my own money issues: stigma. Stigma, other than being a term for the sexy parts of a flower, is defined by the *Cambridge Dictionary* as “a strong feeling of disapproval that most people in a society have about something, especially when this is unfair” (you'll hear that word a lot in this book, because FINANCE IS RIGGED AF). Stigma stifles the flow of information about something so essential to our lives and it leads us to the three buzzkill Musketeers: Shame, Embarrassment, and Anxiety.